predictions of quantum mechanics. He proved something, but what he proved was not “hidden-variable theories can’t work.” This was pointed out by mathematician and philosopher Grete Hermann, but her work was largely ignored.

Along came David Bohm, an interesting and complicated figure in the history of quantum mechanics. As a graduate student in the early 1940s, Bohm became interested in left-wing politics. He ended up working on the Manhattan Project, but he was forced to do his work in Berkeley, as he was denied the necessary security clearance to move to Los Alamos. After the war he became an assistant professor at Princeton, and published an influential textbook on quantum mechanics. In that book he adhered carefully to the received Copenhagen approach, but thinking through the issues made him start wondering about alternatives.

Bohm’s interest in these questions was encouraged by one of the few figures who had the stature to stand up to Bohr and his colleagues: Einstein himself. The great man had read Bohm’s book, and summoned the young professor to his office to talk about the foundations of quantum theory. Einstein explained his basic objections, that quantum mechanics couldn’t be considered a complete view of reality, and encouraged Bohm to think more deeply about the question of hidden variables, which he proceeded to do.

All this took place while Bohm was under a cloud of political suspicion, at a time when association with Communism could ruin people’s careers. In 1949, Bohm had testified before the House Un-American Activities Committee, where he refused to implicate any of his former colleagues. In 1950 he was arrested in his office at Princeton for contempt of Congress. Though he was eventually cleared of all charges, the president of the university forbade him from setting foot on campus, and put pressure on the physics department to not renew his contract. In 1951, with support from Einstein and Oppenheimer, Bohm was eventually able to find a job at the University of São Paulo, and left for Brazil. That’s why the first seminar at Princeton to explain Bohm’s ideas had to be given by someone else.

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None of this drama prevented Bohm from thinking productively about quantum mechanics. Encouraged by Einstein, he developed a theory that